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Source: *The Journal of Religion*, Vol. 88, No. 1 (January 2008), pp. 29-52

Published by: The University of Chicago Press

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/10.1086/522275>

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A Critique of Gordon Kaufman's Theological Method, with Special Reference to His Theory of Religion

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But then, you'll say, God and religion are the same!
(Jonathan Edwards)

Gordon D. Kaufman is a writer whose very name evokes an entire approach to theology: "imaginative construction." Thirty years after the initial publication of Kaufman's landmark *An Essay on Theological Method*, his ideas remain a force to be reckoned with.¹ Still appearing in the form of new publications, Kaufman's work has also inspired a diverse array of other theological writers and projects.² At the same time, however, Kaufman's "constructive" theology has been controversial. In discussions of Kaufman, one major component of his work has yet to be explored adequately: the way he incorporates a general theory of religion into his theological method. Many have praised or attacked one or another aspect of Kaufman's approach, but few have looked in detail at the specific way he defines "religion" and the way this affects his theology.³ This has been an unfortunate omission, because theorizing religion is a very important part of Kaufman's theological procedure.

In this article, I will trace the way Kaufman incorporates a particular theory of religion into his theological method. I will go on to discuss problems with that theory of religion and the way these correlate with

¹ Gordon D. Kaufman, *An Essay on Theological Method* (Missoula, MT: Scholars Press, 1975).

² See, e.g., the work of Victor Anderson, Sheila G. Davaney, Wayne Proudfoot, and Mark C. Taylor.

³ Existing, though brief, analyses may be found in Sheila Greeve Davaney, *Pragmatic Historicism: A Theology for the Twenty-first Century* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 2000), 88–90, 174–76; and in Delwin Brown, "History and Mystery in Kaufman's Theology," *Journal of the American Academy of Religion* (1994): 215–16. Joseph A. Colombo also notes that "at the heart of Kaufman's argument is a broadly 'functional' understanding of religion," but Colombo devotes little attention to deconstructing this understanding. Joseph A. Colombo, review of *In Face of Mystery*, by Gordon D. Kaufman, *Journal of Religion* 75 (1995): 135.

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0022-4189/2008/8801-0002\$10.00

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difficulties in Kaufman's theology. Finally, I will suggest some ways that constructive theologians sympathetic to Kaufman's program might revise his theory of religion and thus improve upon his results.

I. "CHRISTIAN THEOLOGY AND THE SCIENTIFIC STUDY OF RELIGION": FOUR POINTS

Kaufman not infrequently notes that theologians should pay close attention to the critical study of religion.⁴ He has stated repeatedly that he wants to make critical theorization about religion integral to his work as a theologian. And he has been saying this ever since 1972, when he published an essay entitled "Christian Theology and the Scientific Study of Religion" in his early book, *God the Problem*. That 1972 essay offers a useful, and still remarkably current, summation of Kaufman's approach. In the next few pages, I will quickly walk through "Christian Theology and the Scientific Study of Religion," in order to show how Kaufman formulates his interconnected understandings of religion and theology.

Kaufman opens "Christian Theology and the Scientific Study of Religion" with a programmatic statement: "Through throwing light on who he [*sic*] is and on the peculiarities of what he is doing, the descriptive study of religion should be of importance and aid to the theologian, and this deeper self-knowledge and self-understanding may have profound effects on the way he does theology as well as on his theological conclusions."⁵ Kaufman clarifies the meaning of this statement by suggesting that theology is a type of intellectual activity that occurs within "a particular segment of culture, the religious sector."⁶ Given that it is a dimension of human culture, religion can be appropriately analyzed using the methods of the social sciences. This kind of social scientific analysis, by showing how religion works and how theology functions as an expression and application of religion, can help Christian theologians better understand their role and purpose. Hence, the claim that "the descriptive study of religion should be of importance and aid to the theologian."

Having made this claim, one may ask, how does Kaufman make good on it? What specific sort of light does he think "the descriptive study

⁴ For programmatic statements from Kaufman on the need for theology to learn from the academic study of religion, see Gordon D. Kaufman, *God—Mystery—Diversity: Christian Theology in a Pluralistic World* (Minneapolis: Fortress, 1996), 2, and *In Face of Mystery: A Constructive Theology* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1993), 12, 26.

⁵ Gordon D. Kaufman, *God the Problem* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1972), 19.

⁶ *Ibid.*, 18.

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of religion" throws on religion and, by extension, on theology? And finally, to whom in particular, among "descriptive" scholars of religion, does he look for this illumination?

I will address the last question first. In the 1972 essay, Kaufman lists the critical scholars most influential on his understanding of religion in a single long footnote. In that footnote, he begins by quoting, in full, Clifford Geertz's definition of religion from the essay "Religion as a Cultural System."⁷ Next, Kaufman cites, as "particularly relevant" for his understanding of religion, Peter L. Berger's *The Sacred Canopy: Elements of a Sociological Theory of Religion*. He goes on to reference Thomas Luckmann's monograph, *The Invisible Religion*, and, finally, Luckmann and Berger's joint effort, *The Social Construction of Reality*.⁸

Peter L. Berger, whose writings of the 1960s suggest that religion sets up a socially constructed "sacred canopy" to block out the menace of anomie, is clearly a significant influence here.⁹ So, too, is Clifford Geertz. Like the work of Berger and Luckmann, Geertz's "Religion as a Cultural System" stresses that religions are characterized by, and provide their adherents with, "coherence."¹⁰ Geertz's essay depicts religions as conceptual frameworks that give experiences "meaningful form."¹¹ Geertz's article also inclines toward a "functionalist"¹² definition

⁷ Ibid., 30 n. 2: "Note in this connection the definition of religion by Clifford Geertz: 'a religion is (1) a system of symbols which acts to (2) establish powerful, pervasive, and long-lasting moods and motivations in men by (3) formulating conceptions of a general order of existence and (4) clothing these conceptions with such an aura of factuality that (5) the moods and motivations seem uniquely realistic.'"

⁸ Ibid., 30.

⁹ Compare Peter L. Berger, *The Sacred Canopy: Elements of a Sociological Theory of Religion* (Garden City, NY: Doubleday Anchor Books, 1969).

¹⁰ Compare Catherine Bell, "'The Chinese Believe in Spirits': Belief and Believing," in *Radical Interpretation in Religion*, ed. Nancy Frankenberry (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2002), 106–7n.

¹¹ Clifford Geertz, "Religion as a Cultural System," in *Language, Truth, and Religious Belief: Studies in Twentieth-Century Theory and Method in Religion*, ed. Nancy K. Frankenberry and Hans H. Penner (Atlanta: Scholars Press, 1999), 212. For a discussion of Geertz's influential use of the "framework" model, see Terry Godlove, *Religion, Interpretation, and Diversity of Belief: The Framework Model from Kant to Durkheim to Davidson* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1989), chap. 3.

¹² Nancy K. Frankenberry and Hans H. Penner, "Geertz's Longlasting Moods, Motivations, and Metaphysical Conceptions," in their *Language, Truth, and Religious Belief*, 230–31: "By claiming that religion is a response to the anxieties that are produced by our experience of cognitive, physical and moral uncertainty, Geertz casts religion in the role of being a response to needs, i.e., the need to reduce uncertainty, to order chaos, to have meaning. It is precisely this kind of attempt to explain religion, or other cultural elements . . . as responses to certain needs by means of causal analysis, that is known as functionalism in the social sciences." For a critique of functionalism on the ground that it commits the logical fallacy of affirming the consequent, see Hans H. Penner, "What's Wrong with Functional Explanations?" in *ibid.*, 246–70.

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of religions as “culture patterns” that help human groups resolve issues of “general orientation” in the face of potential meaninglessness.¹³

In “Christian Theology and the Scientific Study of Religion,” then, Kaufman favors theorists who (whatever their other differences) stress religion’s role in promoting personal and community integration. And the Harvard theologian sustains this emphasis when he gathers threads from these sources to weave his own overall picture of religion. After marshaling evidence primarily from Peter L. Berger and Clifford Geertz, Kaufman concludes that religions may be best understood as “perspectives” for looking at the world. Kaufman explains the image at some length: “The concept of a *perspective*, as I am using it here . . . is derived from psychological, sociological, and historical studies . . . and it attempts to grasp the variety of historically relative but philosophically coherent and intelligible positions that have emerged by use of a model from visual experience, in which the same object appears quite different when seen from different angles or points of view. Each such ‘perspective’ seems to have validity on its own terms and from its own vantage point, but it is not clear that any can claim final validity or truth.”¹⁴

Kaufman goes on to clarify the point of such perspectives: “Thanks to the work of sociologists and psychologists of religion, we can say that religious perspectives develop in order to give a coherent interpretation of life that will sustain the personal and social order.”¹⁵ Expanding further on the nature of religious perspectives, Kaufman also states that such perspectives are themselves composed of smaller components. These smaller building blocks he calls “categories.” A perspective’s categories are its major symbols and concepts, through which it offers a distinctive view of the world.¹⁶

Having discussed the typical form and function of religious perspectives, Kaufman considers ways such perspectives can fail. Religious perspectives, Kaufman says, usually have little difficulty providing their users with order and meaning. Problems, however, can arise if new “experiences do not fit well the categories provided by the perspective.”¹⁷

¹³ Clifford Geertz, “Religion as a Cultural System,” 181, 188.

¹⁴ Kaufman, *God the Problem*, 28; emphasis added.

¹⁵ *Ibid.*, 29.

¹⁶ Compare Gordon D. Kaufman, *The Theological Imagination: Constructing the Concept of God* (Philadelphia: Westminster, 1981), 102, and *God—Mystery—Diversity*, 61.

¹⁷ On this point, cf. Kaufman, *In Face of Mystery*, 344: “It is clear that ongoing experience and reflection are capable of effecting enormous changes in our world-pictures and our metaphysical conceptions. That is, experience can *disconfirm* features of our most comprehensive images and concepts, as Karl Popper has argued, even though it cannot directly confirm them; it exercises an ongoing negative check on our conceptual and imagistic frames of orientation” (emphasis added).

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At such a point, “the perspective itself is threatened.”¹⁸ A perspective in such straits can only be saved through the efforts of “creative interpreters or prophets (theologians, if you like) who by stretching and reinterpreting the categories in new ways make them again serviceable, or else—if the crisis is serious enough—the perspective will die and another ultimately take its place.”¹⁹

Kaufman's description of theologians as creative interpreters who repair endangered perspectives provides him with the basis for a new theological method. Viewing Christianity as a religious perspective, whose purpose is to provide life orientation, and which may flounder when its categories become outmoded, “now enables us to specify further the Christian theological task. . . . It is the job of the Christian theologian to show that the Christian categories can in fact make sense out of contemporary experience. . . . Unless it can be shown that talk about God, for example, is required to do justice to certain features of our contemporary experience, that category cannot be sustained, and the Christian perspective will abandon it . . . or else that perspective itself will gradually die.”²⁰

In sum, then, in the 1972 essay, “Christian Theology and the Scientific Study of Religion,” Kaufman comes to four basic conclusions about the nature of religion, and hence of theology, based on attention to religion's critical study:²¹

1. Religions are “perspectives,” whose primary purpose is to “give a coherent interpretation of life that will sustain the personal and social order”: “a holistic interpretation of human existence and the world.”²²
2. Perspectives are made up of categories.
3. When one or more of a perspective's categories fails to do justice to contemporary experience, the perspective itself will be in danger of failing.
4. System failure of the entire perspective can be avoided through the intervention of theologians. Theologians are intellectuals who reinterpret and reorder the categories of a religious perspective. In extreme cases, theologians may only be able to save their perspective by excising some of its categories entirely.

¹⁸ Kaufman, *God the Problem*, 31.

¹⁹ Ibid.

²⁰ Ibid.

²¹ The delineation of these four points is mine, not Kaufman's. I focus on these points merely as a way of calling attention to the basic structure and content of Kaufman's argument.

²² Kaufman, *God the Problem*, 29, 35.

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II. KAUFMAN ON RELIGION: ELABORATIONS AND RECONSIDERATIONS

Throughout his more recent writings, Kaufman has remained true to the basic picture of religion and theology sketched in the 1972 essay examined above.²³ He has, to be sure, filled in details beyond those included in his original sketch. Whereas the 1972 essay simply calls religions “perspectives,” for example, Kaufman’s writings of the 1980s, the 1990s, and of the present decade supplement that term with a number of equivalents. Among the rough equivalents Kaufman substitutes for, or adds to, the term “perspective” in later writings on religion are the following: conceptual and interpretive frame,²⁴ conceptual framework,²⁵ conceptual scheme,²⁶ conceptual world,²⁷ frame of orientation and commitment,²⁸ framework for orientation,²⁹ general framework,³⁰ holistic frame of orientation,³¹ imagistic frame,³² map of the world,³³ mythic map,³⁴ symbolic frame,³⁵ symbolic system,³⁶ symbolic world,³⁷ world picture,³⁸ and (most frequently and importantly of all), worldview.³⁹ Despite their variety, these terms express a coherent, and consistent, understanding of religion.

According to this understanding, a religion is a comprehensive world-

²³ Compare Gordon D. Kaufman, *In Face of Mystery*, chap. 16; *God—Mystery—Diversity*, intro., chap. 3; *In the Beginning . . . Creativity* (Minneapolis: Fortress, 2004), epilogue; *The Theological Imagination*, chap. 4. Regarding his sources, Kaufman quotes Clifford Geertz’s definition of religion, in full, once more in *The Theological Imagination* (303) and approvingly mentions the Geertz essay again in *In Face of Mystery* (477). Berger’s *Sacred Canopy* is referenced a second time in an essay on “God as Symbol,” in *God the Problem* (90), and crops up again in a long footnote to *In Face of Mystery*—in the latter instance, still in conjunction with Geertz’s “Religion as a Cultural System” (477). When Kaufman references other scholars of religion in his recent work, he tends to pick writers who reinforce the thematic emphases of Berger and Geertz. He approvingly cites Dutch sociologist Hans Mol’s *Identity and the Sacred* (New York: Free Press, 1976), which stresses that religion functions to “safeguard . . . and reinforce . . . orderly interpretations of reality, rules, and legitimations.” Although Kaufman rejects Mircea Eliade’s mystical bent, he nevertheless appreciatively, and repeatedly, references Eliade on the inescapable human need for orientation (*In Face of Mystery*, 468–69, 251–53, 479).

²⁴ Kaufman, *God—Mystery—Diversity*, 86.

²⁵ *Ibid.*, 61.

²⁶ Kaufman, *In the Beginning . . . Creativity*, 5–6, 208.

²⁷ Kaufman, *God—Mystery—Diversity*, 32.

²⁸ *Ibid.*, 209.

²⁹ *Ibid.*, 64.

³⁰ *Ibid.*, 32.

³¹ *Ibid.*, 60.

³² *Ibid.*, 58.

³³ Kaufman, *In Face of Mystery*, 257.

³⁴ *Ibid.*, 332.

³⁵ *Ibid.*, 39.

³⁶ Kaufman, *In the Beginning . . . Creativity*, 123.

³⁷ *Ibid.*, 96.

³⁸ *Ibid.*, 120.

³⁹ Kaufman, *God—Mystery—Diversity*, 5–6, 58.

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view that plays a central role in the lives of its adherents, at both the individual and corporate levels. At the individual level, every healthy religion offers an "all-encompassing"⁴⁰ scheme that its members use to organize the raw data of their experience.⁴¹ Each one a distinctive "interpretive grid,"⁴² religious worldviews "shape and interpret the experience of all those living in that world."⁴³ For their individual adherents, religious worldviews define not only facts but values. They guide both perception and decision making.

In addition to organizing the lives of individuals, religious worldviews also tie together the lives of whole societies. Throughout most of history, Kaufman states:

It was a people's religion that gave them a sense of solidarity as a group, uniting them in a common cause and a common sense of meaning (Durkheim). The symbol-system and the ritualistic practices of the religion helped fuse the biological energies of the people with their deeply felt bonds of social and personal interconnectedness, focusing their consciousness and their activities in terms defined by a particular "center of value" (H. R. Niebuhr) or complex of values and meanings. The religion of a people, thus, not only provided them with meaningful orientation in life (as I have suggested frequently here): it simultaneously evoked powerful motivations and loyalties that energized and directed their common life.⁴⁴

According to Kaufman's writings of recent years, religions produce personal and social life integration most effectively when they embody convictions taken on faith, or accepted implicitly, by their adherents.⁴⁵ By contrast, when a religion's categories begin to clash with the rest of its users' knowledge and value-certainties, problems develop. Religion loses its credibility. Since religion can no longer provide human lives with a trustworthy "center," society begins to crumble.⁴⁶ Constructive theology is what happens when savvy users of a religious perspective

⁴⁰ Kaufman, *In Face of Mystery*, 325.

⁴¹ "It is necessary to distinguish carefully," Kaufman writes on this score, "the conceptual and interpretive images and frameworks that we employ in our reflection from the raw existential and experiential data to which they give form and meaning." Kaufman, *God—Mystery—Diversity*, 86; cf. *In Face of Mystery*, 324.

⁴² Kaufman, *In Face of Mystery*, 324.

⁴³ Kaufman, *God—Mystery—Diversity*, 143, and cf. "we must have a worldview, a conceptual scheme, within which to order the 'blooming, buzzing confusion' of life . . . or we will not be able to live and act at all. Our great religious traditions have supplied us with such world-pictures" (6).

⁴⁴ Kaufman, *In Face of Mystery*, 226–27. Note the resemblance in the last sentence of this quotation to Clifford Geertz's famous "moods and motivations."

⁴⁵ Compare Kaufman, "Reading Wittgenstein: Notes for Constructive Theologians," *Journal of Religion* 79 (1999): 418ff.

⁴⁶ See Kaufman, *In the Beginning . . . Creativity*, 34, and *In Face of Mystery*, 71, 187, 313, 432–33, 444.

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rework it so as to mesh with the rest of what has come to be “take[n] for granted” in a changing culture.⁴⁷

As is well known, Kaufman has produced his own reconstruction of the Christian worldview, using the understanding of religion/theology outlined above. The details of this constructive effort are readily available elsewhere, and I will not explore them extensively here. Instead, I would like to pursue a less familiar, but equally important, line of inquiry. It is time to ask: How adequate is the understanding of religion on which Kaufman’s theological method, and ultimately his theological findings, are based? Does Kaufman’s theory of religion bear up well against available evidence?

From the 1970s to the present day, Kaufman’s work has consistently portrayed religions (in their “normal” state) as internally coherent,⁴⁸ all-embracing,⁴⁹ taken for granted⁵⁰ worldviews, whose primary function is to provide life orientation.⁵¹ I think Kaufman paints a one-sided picture on all of these counts. A short survey of evidence from various religious situations—recent and premodern, local and distant—will provide reasons for calling Kaufman’s worldview characterization of religion into question.

A. *Internal Coherence*

I take up first the matter of religious worldviews’ “coherence.” Kaufman states that “in traditional Christian faith . . . the monotheistic categorial scheme . . . drew all the diversity and multiplicity of life—indeed, of the entire world process—together into a *coherent pattern* or unity in terms of which the concrete decisions of daily life could be made.”⁵² Elsewhere he describes the typical “traditional [religious] world picture” (monotheistic or otherwise) as characterized by “systematic interconnectedness” and suggests that up until “the last two or three hundred years” Christians enjoyed a “consensus about the meanings of . . . [their] important symbols.”⁵³ “Coherent,” “systematic,” “consensus”—do these words accurately characterize most religious practice, now or in the past? I think evidence shows that the picture is more complicated than that.

⁴⁷ On this point, see Kaufman, *God—Mystery—Diversity*, chap. 2, and also “Reading Wittgenstein,” 418–20.

⁴⁸ Kaufman, *In Face of Mystery*, 308.

⁴⁹ *Ibid.*, 325.

⁵⁰ *Ibid.*, 285.

⁵¹ Kaufman, *God—Mystery—Diversity*, 6.

⁵² Kaufman, *In Face of Mystery*, 308; emphasis added.

⁵³ Kaufman, “Reading Wittgenstein,” 419, and *In the Beginning . . . Creativity*, 34.

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A good place to begin a reassessment of the idea that religion is defined by coherence may be found in the work of Catherine Bell, known for her work on the theory of ritual. Bell notes in a recent article that “it is a relatively recent thing for scholars to emphasize meaningful and systematic coherence in relation to what religion is all about. Only in the second half of the twentieth century, for the most part, has the provision of coherence been seen as the defining role of religion, that is, what we theorists think it should do when religion can no longer explain the nature of the universe or act as the authoritative source of morality.”⁵⁴ She goes on to point out, significantly for the purposes of a study of Gordon Kaufman (given the sources for the descriptive study of religion that he cites most consistently), that “influences on the [current] interpretive importance of coherence have been Peter L. Berger’s arguments about the construction of a *nomos* as a meaningful order (*The Sacred Canopy* . . .); and Clifford Geertz’s arguments about religions as a system (‘Religion as a Cultural System’ . . .).”⁵⁵

Despite the current popularity of the notion that religion provides coherence, Bell contends that close study of both twentieth-century American, and traditional Chinese, religious practices does not support this hypothesis. Reflecting on both her formal research and personal experiences growing up, Bell comments on

how readily people get by without giving much attention to making any larger sense of things. It was clear to me growing up among the natives of Long Island in the 1950s and 1960s—indeed, it was a striking feature of the religious attitudes there—just how little coherence religion actually seemed to provide or was even expected to provide. . . . On Long Island, and in other places I have come to know well, what is thought of as religion by the natives is more a matter of loosely packaged sets of behaviors—what we can also call “bundles of behaviors” or “habits of action.” For Long Islanders, these packaged sets of distinct behaviors were used to deal with such events as death, serious illness, perverse misfortune, and occasionally life-crises like birth, marriage, or divorce. . . . In actual fact, family, jobs, and personal projects of service to others were more obvious overarching systems of meaning; religion appeared to be invoked simply to support them. Long Islanders’ delineation and expectations of religion are not the same as those of other places that could be described. Yet neither are these places so different that we cannot articulate similarities and differences.⁵⁶

Bell proposes that what is called “religion” is typically marked, not by

⁵⁴ Bell, “The Chinese Believe in Spirits,” 107.

⁵⁵ *Ibid.*, 107–8.

⁵⁶ *Ibid.*, 108–9.

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systematic coherence but rather by “a complex array of compartmentalizations and disassociations.”⁵⁷

Bell's argument builds constructively on a long-standing Western recognition of the supposed “incoherence” of some religious practice in non-Western societies, especially Asian ones. Some eighty years ago, sociologist Max Weber remarked that many Chinese acted as religious “independent voters,” drawing on resources from Buddhism, Confucianism, and religious Taoism without restricting themselves to any one of these supposedly global systems of meaning. “Many Chinese have been brought up in the Confucian ethic,” he noted, “yet still consult Taoist divining priests before building a house. . . . Chinese will mourn deceased relatives according to the Confucian rule while also arranging for Buddhist masses to be performed in their memory.”⁵⁸ Other observers have commented on similar tendencies in Japan: “A distinctive feature of Japanese religious history is that individuals usually have not belonged exclusively to one religious tradition but consciously affiliated themselves with or participated in several traditions. . . . In Japan, it has been customary for a person (or family) to participate in both Shinto festivals and Buddhist memorial services and to practice Confucian ethics and follow beliefs of religious Taoism and folk religion. . . . The person was Shinto *and* Buddhist *and* Confucian *and* Taoist.”⁵⁹ Where Bell differs from some earlier scholars is in positing that such conceptual multiplicity may be less the exception, and more the rule, within human religious history.⁶⁰

Bell's proposals fit evidence from a range of religious settings—not just contemporary North America or traditional China.⁶¹ Her work also accords with that of certain other theorists. Ernest Gellner, for instance, has noted that “accounts of societies in terms of the beliefs and values of their members often assume that each member has one set

⁵⁷ Ibid., 109.

⁵⁸ Max Weber, *The Sociology of Religion*, trans. Ephraim Fischhoff (Boston: Beacon, 1993), 62. Compare Michael Saso, “Chinese Religions,” in *A New Handbook of Living Religions*, ed. John R. Hinnells (Oxford: Blackwell, 1997), 446.

⁵⁹ H. Byron Earhart, *Japanese Religion: Unity and Diversity*, 3rd ed. (Belmont, CA: Wadsworth, 1982), 3–4; emphasis added.

⁶⁰ For further elaborations see Catherine Bell, *Ritual Theory, Ritual Practice* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1992), 184–85.

⁶¹ Compare Wade Clark Roof, *Spiritual Marketplace: Baby Boomers and the Remaking of American Religion* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1999); Peter G. Stromberg, *Symbols of Community: The Cultural System of a Swedish Church* (Tucson: University of Arizona Press, 1986); Charles H. Lippy, *Being Religious, American Style: A History of Popular Religiosity in the United States* (Westport, CT: Greenwood, 1994); Richard Godbeer, *The Devils' Dominion: Magic and Religion in Early New England* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1992), 36; David D. Hall, *Worlds of Wonder, Days of Judgment: Popular Religious Belief in Early New England* (New York: Knopf, 1989), 162.

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of beliefs about the world, and one set of values. This seems to me a major mistake. Any professional sports team invariably has more than one reserve in addition to the set normally presented to the public, ever ready to replace the first lot, either one by one or, if necessary, as a whole. The same is generally true about our cosmological picture or our moral values.”⁶² Taking seriously the arguments of scholars like Gellner and Bell might have important consequences for Kaufman's theory of religion and for his theological method.

B. Religions as “Taken for Granted”

According to Gordon Kaufman, religious worldviews are not only marked by conceptual coherence but have also been accepted fairly uncritically by most of their users. Kaufman sums up as follows: “In traditional religious communities (and in more traditional theological work) . . . the basic framework which made it possible to understand the world and human life to be ‘under God’ was *taken for granted, simply accepted from tradition*. Hence, questions about the components of this frame were *never raised*. One committed oneself (in one's believing) to the whole framework of interpretation; and life was lived as much as possible in the terms it defined and prescribed—or perhaps in rebellion against those terms, but never independently of them.”⁶³

Kaufman's evocation of a traditional religiosity characterized by “givenness-as-a-systematic-interconnected-whole,” and about which “questions . . . were never raised,” conjures up images of a lost age of faith. Although the accuracy of such images may seem self-evident, some scholars have disputed them. Reconsiderations of bygone eras of universal piety have gone hand in hand with criticisms of the so-called secularization theory of straightforward religious decline in modernity.

Sociologist Rodney Stark's assault on the secularization hypothesis has garnered some notoriety and is worth considering, given the questions it raises about Kaufman's view of religion. In his article, “Secularization: R.I.P.,” Stark challenges not only the theory of a long-term decline of religion in the West but also the concept of an “age of faith” wherein religion was taken for granted by the mass of the populace. Stark confronts point blank what “everyone ‘knows’”: that is, “that once upon a time the world was pious—that in olden days most people exhibited levels of religious practice and concern that today linger only in isolated subcultures such as the Amish, ultra-orthodox Jews, or Mus-

⁶² Ernest Gellner, “Doctor and Saint,” in *Islam in Tribal Societies: From the Atlas to the Indus*, ed. Akbar S. Ahmed and David M. Hart (London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1984), 21.

⁶³ Kaufman, *In Face of Mystery*, 285; emphasis added.

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lim fundamentalists.” “Like so many once-upon-a-time tales,” Stark states, “this conception of a pious past is mere nostalgia.” Based on the close study of the available evidence about church buildings, monasticism, politically engineered nationwide “conversions,” parish clergy, and religiosity among serfs and nobles, Stark says, “most prominent historians of medieval religion now agree that there never was an ‘Age of Faith.’”⁶⁴

Sociologists fond of the secularization hypothesis, Stark claims, often have “very exaggerated perceptions of past religiousness”—perceptions that can be distressing to scholars who actually concentrate on medieval materials:

Historians have long expressed dismay at “unhistorically minded sociologists” for clinging to the myth of Europe’s lost piety, complaining that “not enough justice has been done to the volume of apathy, heterodoxy, and agnosticism that existed long before the onset of industrialization.” . . . A substantial proportion of medieval populations did not take their religious beliefs very seriously. Nor must we forget that a significant number, probably about the same as today, rejected religious beliefs. As Franklin Baumer put it, “Contrary to popular supposition there was plenty of skepticism in the Middle Ages, and some of it was quite radical.” Judging from the prevalence of blasphemous graffiti on the walls of Pompeii, the same must be said of the Greco-Roman era.⁶⁵

Stark sums up the implications of his study as follows:

It simply is not true . . . that modern life contrasts sharply with life in simple societies when it comes to the prevalence of religious belief. . . . Unbelief is not uncommon in preliterate societies. . . . Alexander Murray, having demonstrated that the original sources are nearly unanimous in their admission of widespread irreligiousness in medieval times, asked from whence came the notion of the Age of Faith. He concluded: “The scientific enlightenment was tempted to conceive faith not as a virtue, but as an original sin, from which the Messiah of knowledge came to rescue it. It follows from that view that, in the olden days, men must have believed all the Church told them. This paper has tried to shake the historical part of that conception.”⁶⁶

⁶⁴ Rodney Stark, “Secularization: R.I.P.,” in *The Secularization Debate*, ed. William H. Swatos and Daniel V. A. Olson (Lanham, MD: Rowman & Littlefield, 2000), 47.

⁶⁵ Ibid., 52, 55.

⁶⁶ Ibid., 61–62. On irreligion in premodern or early modern settings, see also Jon Butler, *Awash in a Sea of Faith: Christianizing the American People* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1990), 20; William Bascom, *Ifa Divination: Communication between Gods and Men in West Africa* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1969), 119. For parallels from the classical world, see Marcus Tullius Cicero, *The Nature of the Gods and On Divination*, trans. C. D. Yonge (Amherst, NY: Prometheus Books, 1997), 221: “There is an old saying of Cato, familiar enough

Not all sociologists are as willing as Rodney Stark to dismiss the very idea of secularization.⁶⁷ But Stark is far from alone in challenging the notion of a bygone, universal “age of faith.” Sociologists William H. Swatos and Kevin J. Christiano, for example, join Stark in pointing out the lack of evidence for “the underlying myth of secularization theory,” that is, the notion “that ‘in the past’ people were significantly more religious than they are today . . . that sometime, someplace in the past there was a solidary [*sic*] Age of Faith in which ‘the world was filled with the sacred.’”⁶⁸ Swatos and Christiano, however, extend Stark’s critique by questioning not only the high level of religiosity in premodern societies but also the assumption that such societies have usually been religious monocultures. They grant that “the numbers of options among which people may choose (or the degree of pluralism) obviously increases with globalization and with the advance of alternative knowledge paradigms. However, again, it is not the case that pluralism did not exist in the past. . . . The Roman world into which Christianity came was filled with competing ideological systems, wherein part of the putative uniqueness of Christianity was its claim to exclusivity. . . . There is a substantial body of evidence that pluralism of belief—including disbelief—has been an option throughout history that is simply intensified by globalization.”⁶⁹ All told, Swatos and Christiano weigh in against assumptions that religion was ordinarily “taken for granted” by individual believers, or fixed and stable in its social role, before the onset of modernity: “An underlying assumption of secularization theory that pluralism . . . challenges is the idea that ‘religion’ is something fixed. Instead, sociologists of religion need to recognize the tentativeness and fragility of religious structures of meaning. . . . As ideational systems, religions are always in interaction with material culture, social structure, other cultural systems, and individual personalities. . . . [Secularization theory] within the sociology of religion has underwritten conceptions of ‘religion’ as essentially fixed rather than

to everybody, that ‘he wondered that when one soothsayer met another, he could help laughing.’ . . . When Hannibal fled to Prusias, and was eager to wage war with the enemy, that monarch replied that he dared not do so, because the entrails of the sacrifice wore an unfavorable aspect. ‘Would you then,’ said Hannibal, ‘rather trust a bit of calf’s flesh than a veteran general?’ And as to Caesar, when he was warned by the chief soothsayer not to venture into Africa before the winter, did he not cross?” With respect to the ancient Near East, James Barr has pointed to skeptical currents in the Hebrew Bible; see James Barr, *Biblical Faith and Natural Theology* (Oxford: Clarendon, 1993), 153–54.

⁶⁷ For a good bibliography of works on the secularization hypothesis, see Linell Cady, “Secularism, Secularizing, and Secularization: Reflections on Stout’s *Democracy and Tradition*,” *Journal of the American Academy of Religion* 73 (2005): 871–85.

⁶⁸ *Ibid.*, 11–12.

⁶⁹ *Ibid.*, 15.

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essentially variable. Sociologically, however, there is far more reason to conceive [of] religion as variable.”⁷⁰

Together with other recent revisers of secularization theory, Swatos and Christiano prefer to stress the changing social function of religious institutions within societies, rather than to argue for a straightforward decline in levels of personal religious belief. An approach like theirs is able to take seriously the high levels of anticlericalism or even personal skepticism recorded in some outwardly religious societies. At the same time, however, such an approach recognizes that the part religion plays in public life has observably altered in Western societies. Kaufman’s treatment of religion would be well served by taking account of such theoretical shifts. If Kaufman were to recognize that religious beliefs have not always been taken for granted, or even taken completely at face value,⁷¹ by their users, this might have significant consequences for his program.

C. Religions as “All-Embracing”

According to Gordon Kaufman, religious worldviews not only tend to be coherent and taken for granted but also tend to be “all-encompassing.”⁷² Kaufman thinks, that is, that under normal conditions a religion “pervades the whole of life,”⁷³ leaving nothing untouched for its users.⁷⁴ But is it true that religious worldviews are all pervasive for those who use them? As is well known, anthropologist Bronislaw Malinowski did not think so. In a classic series of articles, Malinowski argued that supernatural beliefs are used for specific purposes and under particular conditions, rather than blanketing the whole of life (even in a traditional society).⁷⁵

More recently, French classicist Paul Veyne has mounted a similar argument regarding the ancient Greeks. Among classical Greek and Roman authors, Veyne notes, it is curious but true that the same writer can be found treating a given myth with, by turns, credulity and skepticism. Veyne’s interpretation of this is that Greek writers approached

⁷⁰ Ibid., 16.

⁷¹ See Jonathan Z. Smith, *Map Is Not Territory: Studies in the History of Religions* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1993), 300–302, for some examples of this.

⁷² Kaufman, *In Face of Mystery*, 325.

⁷³ Ibid., 74.

⁷⁴ Compare Terry Godlove, *Religion, Interpretation, and Diversity of Belief*, 83: “Religious belief systems . . . are, says Kaufman, able to interpret ‘every feature of experience and life,’ everything, it would appear, from the origin of evil to the preparing of a meal.”

⁷⁵ Bronislaw Malinowski, *Magic, Science, and Religion, and Other Essays* (New York: Doubleday Anchor, 1954).

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their mythology differently based on their immediate rhetorical aims and needs. Veyne cites the example of the physician Galen. "Did he," Veyne asks, "or did he not believe in Centaurs?" Veyne's own answer is "It depends."

When he is speaking as a scholar and laying out his personal theories, he speaks of the Centaurs in terms that imply that for himself and his most select readers these marvelous beings had barely any present reality. . . . But when the same Galen no longer seeks to impose his ideas but to win new disciples, he seems to pass to the side of the believers. Summarizing his whole view of medicine . . . and determined to give the most lofty idea of this science, he offers an account of its high origin [in] . . . "the knowledge of the centaur Chiron."⁷⁶

Perhaps even more relevant for a contemporary reassessment of the idea that religions are typically all-embracing is the work of University of Chicago historian of religions Jonathan Z. Smith.⁷⁷ In many articles and monographs, Smith has contested the assumption that religions, even in traditional or premodern settings, are holistically, automatically all-encompassing for their users.⁷⁸ Through close readings of religious materials, Smith explores the creativity summoned forth in religionists at precisely those moments when congruity fails—that is, in cases in which a religion fails to "embrace" everything.⁷⁹ Smith stresses that acts of religious creativity inevitably reflect particular "interests" and explores the wide range of strategies whereby religious materials may be deployed in order to deal with the unexpected.⁸⁰ All told, Smith's body of work offers an imposing counterweight to Kaufman's claim that religion has customarily been totalistic. Furthermore, instead of implying, like Kaufman, that religious reconstruction must be undertaken relatively infrequently—periodically, "in each new era,"⁸¹ Smith stresses

⁷⁶ Paul Veyne, *Did the Greeks Believe in Their Myths? An Essay on the Constitutive Imagination*, trans. Paula Wissing (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1988), 54–55.

⁷⁷ On the ongoing relevance of Smith's work, see Russell T. McCutcheon, "Relating Smith: Review Essay of Jonathan Z. Smith's *Relating Religion*," *Journal of Religion* 86 (2006): 287–97; also Jay Geller, "En Jeu: Lincoln Logs or Pick-Up Sticks," *Method and Theory in the Study of Religion* 17 (2005): 18–19.

⁷⁸ See Jonathan Z. Smith, *Map Is Not Territory*, esp. chap. 13; *Imagining Religion: From Babylon to Jonestown* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1982), esp. chaps. 3–7; *To Take Place: Toward Theory in Ritual* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1987); and *Relating Religion: Essays in the Study of Religion* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2004), esp. chaps. 4–6, 11.

⁷⁹ Smith, *Map Is Not Territory*, 293–94, 296–98.

⁸⁰ Compare the comments of Smith cited in Robert G. Hamerton-Kelly, ed., *Violent Origins: Walter Burkert, René Girard, and Jonathan Z. Smith on Ritual Killing and Cultural Formation* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 1987), 186–88. For a discussion of Smith's use of the term "interest," see Burton Mack's comments on 69–70 of the same volume; see also Jonathan Z. Smith, "Playful Acts of Imagination," *Liberal Education* 73 (1987): 14–20.

⁸¹ Kaufman, *God—Mystery—Diversity*, 50.

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the ordinariness and ceaselessness of such revisionary activity. For Smith, religious reconstruction goes on constantly, precisely because religions can never successfully “embrace” everything (and must always scramble to deal with this or that incongruity).⁸²

Smith’s work, like Malinowski’s classic arguments and Veyne’s literary/philosophical musings, invites one to consider the possibility that religions are not best thought of as inherently “all-embracing.” It may well be true that religious resources are potentially applicable to any given facet of human life (as Durkheim said, after all, anything can be sacred). But to concede that possibility is different from stating that in a traditional society, the members’ “social, political, and economic institutions, family patterns, customs surrounding work and leisure, the stories they tell and the songs they sing . . . are all in certain respects ordered and organized in relationship to this categorial pattern . . . so that every object or event . . . is experienced in terms of this categorial pattern.”⁸³

D. Religious Worldviews as Providers of Orientation

According to Gordon Kaufman, “if we ask what human societies are *doing* when they create religious traditions, and what individuals are doing when they participate in them, we can answer that they are seeking to gain orientation in life.”⁸⁴ Since religions are primarily in existence to provide orientation, they are for Kaufman first and foremost preoccupied with organizing behavior and only (at best) secondarily concerned with serving any other purposes: “Religious traditions . . . serve the human need to find orientation in the world and life. Not orientation for this present moment of experience or this particular small decision—such orientation might be provided by pop psychology, by prejudice, or simply by the regularities of custom or habit. Rather . . . orientation for the long haul, for life as a whole, orientation for one’s children and one’s children’s children, for one’s whole society, indeed, for all humanity.”⁸⁵

Kaufman’s emphasis on religion’s role as orientator is tied to his laudation of “radical monotheism” (a term he takes over from H. Richard Niebuhr). For Kaufman, monotheism is an apt expression of reli-

⁸² Jonathan Z. Smith, *Map Is Not Territory*, 308, and cf. “No Need to Travel to the Indies: Judaism and the Study of Religion,” in *Take Judaism, for Example*, ed. Jacob Neusner (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1983), 224.

⁸³ Kaufman, *In Face of Mystery*, 80.

⁸⁴ *Ibid.*, 70.

⁸⁵ Kaufman, *God—Mystery—Diversity*, 6.

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gion's most basic function, because devotion to a single God provides a very effective basis for structuring human lives. Monotheism directs the human gaze toward a center of value that transcends anything finite. This center of value is able to pull all finite realities and concerns into a balanced order. Religions that do not resemble radical monotheism in this respect risk being labeled as idolatry by Kaufman. Consider the following quotation from *In Face of Mystery*:

The image/concept of God addresses the need for a center of orientation and devotion which is not a mere extrapolation of human desires and wishes—one which is, that is to say, in some sense significantly “outside” or “beyond” everything human. As finite beings seeking security and satisfaction, men and women all too easily make themselves the center of life. . . . What is needed to break through this curved-in character of human existence is a center and focus of meaning which can draw us out of our preoccupation with ourselves and our own wishes, our social groups and their parochial interests and biases, our anthropocentrism. The image/concept of a God radically “objective” to human beings, entirely independent of all our desires and not susceptible to any remaking or reshaping in accord with our wishes, that which we can in no way control, has traditionally performed this function. Devotion to such a God is able to overcome the warfare of a thousand idolatrous interests and desires, opening human existence to meanings and values and patterns of order otherwise beyond reach. (The symbol “God,” of course, is not the only human imaginative construct capable of deparochializing and universalizing effects; in other traditions symbols like “Brahman” or “sunyatta” have performed similar functions.)⁸⁶

Here Kaufman implies that religion focused on short-term goals such as “security and satisfaction,” religion that is not actively “deparochializing and universalizing,” is “idolatrous.” In his published oeuvre, Kaufman spends little time on such pragmatic religiosity and never appears to take it seriously. For Kaufman, genuine religion appears to be identified with devotion to transcendent (somewhat abstract) concepts like *sunyatta*, Brahman, and the YHWH of the Israelite prophets—rather than with the worship of wish-granting beings such as West African *orishas*, certain East Asian bodhisattvas, or medieval Catholic saints.⁸⁷

In contrast to Kaufman, many analysts of “popular” religion have stressed the way that, for rank-and-file practitioners, religion often has been very much about addressing immediate, short-term concerns. This can be seen in scholarly treatments of, for instance, contemporary American spirituality, traditional Chinese religion, ancient and modern

⁸⁶ Kaufman, *In Face of Mystery*, 312–13.

⁸⁷ For Kaufman's sharp words about Amida Buddha, popular among many rank-and-file Buddhists, see Kaufman, *God—Mystery—Diversity*, chaps. 8, 10.

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Hinduism, and medieval Catholic Christianity.⁸⁸ In such literature, statements such as the following are not infrequent: “The function of religion was to give support to [traditional Chinese] people in coping with the problems resulting from the unpredictable and capricious aspects of the world, rather than to provide an intellectually satisfying cosmology.”⁸⁹ Or “the majority of [modern Indian] villagers . . . are concerned not so much with the higher realms of metaphysical speculation . . . but rather with the practical, pragmatic side of religion. This latter aspect of religion, which seeks to attain ends in this world—a son, a good crop, recovery from illness, etc.—is as much a part of Hinduism as any other aspect, and has been at least since the time of the *Atharva-veda*.”⁹⁰ Evidence indicates that for many people, throughout much of history, religion has been precisely about attaining “our wishes”—as much as, if not more than, about providing a transcendent, “deparochializing” point of orientation.

As with other aspects of Kaufman’s understanding of religion, the problem here is not that Kaufman has missed the boat entirely. Instead, the difficulty is with the one-sidedness of Kaufman’s portrayal. In stressing ethical guidance and the provision of ultimate meaning, Kaufman underemphasizes the many other uses to which religions can be put in the lives of their participants.

IV. KAUFMAN’S THEOLOGY: A REASSESSMENT

As I have tried to show, I think Kaufman’s theory of religion is problematically one-sided. His picture of religions as worldviews overstates religions’ unanimity, their singleness of purpose, their unquestioning acceptance by traditional population groups. In my view, a lopsided theory of religion may be partly responsible for difficulties in Kaufman’s theology. Among contemporary theologians, even those most sympathetic to Kaufman have sometimes questioned his method and findings. Kaufman’s fellow constructive theologian, Peter C. Hodgson, for example, has spoken of a “frustrating vagueness at the heart” of Kaufman’s theology. “Toward the end” of Kaufman’s major work, *In Face of Mystery*, Hodgson writes,

Kaufman summarizes [his concept of God] as follows: “Throughout I have been suggesting that we identify God (or better: God’s activity) with actual cosmic, vital, and historical powers or forces at work in the world—especially

⁸⁸ Lippy, *Being Religious, American Style*, Roof, *Spiritual Marketplace*, 83, 86, 91.

⁸⁹ Laurence G. Thompson, *Chinese Religion*, 3rd ed. (Belmont, CA: Wadsworth, 1989), 19.

⁹⁰ Simon Weightman, “Hinduism,” in *A New Handbook of Living Religions*, ed. John R. Hinnells (Oxford: Blackwell, 1997), 294.

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those which have brought us into being, which continue to sustain us in being, and which are drawing us onward toward a more profound humanization." The parenthetical qualification and the clause following the dash express the central unresolved tensions in Kaufman's doctrine of God. If "God" is distinguishable from "God's activity," and if this means that "God" is not simply a cosmic force, what then *is* "God"? Does not activity require an agent or actor? What sort of agent is God? Is God's activity *all* of the cosmic powers or a certain trajectory of powers?⁹¹

I suggest that some of the "unresolved tensions" Hodgson notes in Kaufman's theology are related to problems with Kaufman's understanding of religion.

According to Kaufman, it will be remembered, a religion is a "holistic frame of orientation."⁹² A religion is a holistic frame in that it touches on all aspects of adherents' lives and is integrated into the warp and woof of their most basic assumptions about the universe.⁹³ By the same token, a religion is a frame of orientation in that it provides an "ultimate point of reference" around which lives can be organized.⁹⁴ As noted above, the paradigmatic expression of this aspect of religious life is found in those religions whose ultimate reference point fully transcends identification with any particular item in the world. Such religions (e.g., ancient Israelite monotheism) provide not only clear-cut but also praiseworthy examples of one of religion's most definitive features.⁹⁵

The understanding of religion just rehearsed is kept in mind by Kaufman when he himself begins to theologize. For a religious outlook to work, Kaufman thinks it should have a central point of orientation that will, ideally, transcend immediate goals and objects. In addition, a religious outlook should also mesh well with the larger "(implicit) beliefs" and "value-certainties" that make up the "commonsense everyday world" of the religion's adherents.⁹⁶ Thus, Kaufman believes that contemporary Christian theology must speak of a central reference point for orienting human lives that transcends all finite interests and goals. At the same time, Kaufman thinks modern theology must dovetail with a scientific worldview, since the unspoken background assumptions modern people have about the world are provided by science.

⁹¹ Peter C. Hodgson, review of *In Face of Mystery*, by Gordon D. Kaufman, *Journal of the American Academy of Religion* 62 (1994): 204.

⁹² Kaufman, *God—Mystery—Diversity*, 60.

⁹³ Compare Kaufman, "Reading Wittgenstein," 417–21.

⁹⁴ Kaufman, *God—Mystery—Diversity*, 148.

⁹⁵ Kaufman finds these religions praiseworthy because in them a transcendent reference point relativizes all merely selfish goals.

⁹⁶ Kaufman, "Reading Wittgenstein," 420, 419.

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It is his definition of religion (with his closely related understanding of theological method) that appears at least partly responsible for the “tensions” in Kaufman’s theology noted by sympathetic critics like Peter C. Hodgson. On the one hand, Kaufman thinks religion/theology should call for loyalty to a central reference point transcending anything “in” the world. On the other hand, Kaufman also thinks modern people influenced by science can no longer believe in anything “outside” the empirically quantifiable universe.⁹⁷ Kaufman’s definition of religion/theology puts him in an awkward position. By Kaufman’s own lights, his reconception of Christian belief must include a central point of orientation that transcends all finite objects—but that is still to be found within the empirically quantifiable universe. Hence the “frustrating vagueness” about God or serendipitous creativity: is it a cosmic force, or a transcendent Mystery expressing itself through such a force, and so on?⁹⁸ (This ambiguity in Kaufman’s God doctrine persists even in his most recent reformulations and clarifications. In the second chapter of *In the Beginning . . . Creativity* [2004], Kaufman begins by stressing that serendipitous creativity is not a force and that it must not be reified into some sort of finite object.⁹⁹ At the end of that chapter, however, Kaufman states that serendipitous creativity must be valued “above *all other realities*,” suggesting that serendipitous creativity is a reality like other things in the world, not just a metaphorical expression of some sort.)¹⁰⁰ I contend that Kaufman’s unrealistic picture of religion leaves him with unrealizable goals for his theology. If his picture of religion were altered, however, perhaps those goals could be refined accordingly.

V. MOVING FORWARD

Kaufman’s insistence that theologians learn from the critical study of religion still excites. Despite this, the theory of religion upon which Kaufman himself relies has problems. For the promise in Kaufman’s approach to be realized, therefore, at least two corrections need to be made. First, theologians sympathetic to Kaufman’s approach need to look for a better general theory of religion than is supplied by Kaufman’s worldview model. Second, such theologians need to pay more

⁹⁷ On these points, see also Kaufman, *In the Beginning . . . Creativity*, 54, and *In Face of Mystery*, 271.

⁹⁸ Kaufman puts forward “serendipitous creativity” as “the most fundamental or defining metaphor for God” in his theology. See Kaufman, *In the Beginning . . . Creativity*, 42.

⁹⁹ *Ibid.*, 55–56.

¹⁰⁰ *Ibid.*, 69; emphasis added.

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attention to popular religiosity than Kaufman has done. I will expand briefly on these two suggestions in the following paragraphs.

The writings of Jonathan Z. Smith offer a useful starting point for thinking about alternatives to Kaufman's theory of religion. Smith's name sums up a research tradition in religious studies significantly different from that tapped by Kaufman. This tradition corrects for many of Kaufman's imbalances. Like Kaufman, J. Z. Smith accepts that religions are imaginative constructs and that they can help humans feel at home in the world. Smith, however, generally avoids the problematic language of worldviews when describing religions. Unlike Kaufman, Smith dwells on the diversity of practice and perspective noticeable even in premodern religious settings. As Smith remarks at one point, "the diversity and pluralism of any so-called primitive society can be found to be as complicated as modern San Francisco."¹⁰¹ Smith, furthermore, is clearer than is Kaufman about the way social location, situational circumstances, and interests influence the use of religious resources—even in monotradsitional situations. Smith recognizes, as well, that religious ideas are not always taken for granted in premodern settings. He stresses, to the contrary, that the same motifs may be regarded and used in a wide variety of ways to achieve different ends by religious adherents. All told, the writings of Smith treat religions less as all-encompassing "interpretive grids"¹⁰² and more as collections of "strategies for dealing with a situation."¹⁰³ On an additional and quite important note, Smith also shows a much greater awareness than does Kaufman of the invented and problematic nature of the category religion itself.

Smith's writings on religion have not gone uncriticized. But there is no arguing with the fact that Smith's work has inspired a fruitful tradition of theorization about religion. Among the various scholars and theorists to have taken up Smith's project in recent years, one of the more ambitious is Tim Murphy of the University of Alabama. Murphy has taken up and developed Smith's treatment of "canon" and interpretation into a full-blown "semiotic theory of religion." Building on the work of Smith and others, Murphy defines religion as follows: "Religion has historically been the structuring of asymmetrical relations between real or imagined groups with the involvement of non-ordinary beings, states, and events."¹⁰⁴ Murphy treats any given religion as a

¹⁰¹ Cited in Hamerton-Kelly, *Violent Origins*, 188.

¹⁰² Kaufman, *In Face of Mystery*, 324.

¹⁰³ Smith, *Map Is Not Territory*, 299.

¹⁰⁴ Tim Murphy, "What Is a Semiotic Theory of Religion?" *Bulletin of the Council of Societies for the Study of Religion* 34 (2005): 73.

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hermeneutical process, in which “an ensemble of signifiers,” a “mobile army of metaphors,” provides a set of “paradigmatic elements” from which “hermeneutes select to form syntagmatic combinations.”¹⁰⁵ According to Murphy, religious hermeneutical operations may be carried out for many purposes and in a variety of ways, but they characteristically involve the invocation of “non-ordinary entities such as ‘gods, goddesses, spirits, soul, etc.,’”¹⁰⁶ as well as the establishment of hierarchies or “asymmetries” of value among terms.

The work of Smith, Murphy, and others in conversation with them has, in my view, significant advantages over the treatment of religion favored by Kaufman. To be sure, Smith and his cohorts recognize with Kaufman that religions display order, give some adherents life direction, and can embrace many aspects of life. But they are much better at allowing for the multiplicity, fluidity, and contentiousness observable in what is called religion. They recognize, moreover, the troubled history of the very term “religion” itself. All of these factors commend their work to constructive theologians interested in taking seriously recent moves made in religion’s critical study.

With that said, what type of theological method might prove compatible with such a view of religion? Though the writings of J. Z. Smith and Tim Murphy differ in certain details, both authors stress that religion is a constant process of negotiation. In this process, inherited elements are constantly uncoupled, recoupled, and played off against new conditions in light of particular interests. Consequently, religions are best thought of not as “interpretive grids” that filter every possible experience, but more as collections of “strategies” to be mobilized (Smith), or “armies of metaphors” to be deployed (Murphy). While there is not a total opposition here with Kaufman’s understanding of religion, there is a change of emphasis. In their treatments of religion, Smith and Murphy foreground a constant improvisation in which religious adherents draw on an inherited repertoire to deal with this or that situation. Perhaps theologians should make similar moves.

If theologians accept Kaufman’s “sacred canopy” model of religion, then they will likely visualize themselves as architects, rearing relatively permanent edifices of meaning—“bulwarks against the Void”¹⁰⁷ that will serve “one’s children and one’s children’s children.”¹⁰⁸ Learning from Smith, Murphy, and their cohorts, however, theologians might

¹⁰⁵ Ibid., 70, 74, and “Elements of a Semiotic Theory of Religion,” *Method and Theory in the Study of Religion* 15 (2003): 48.

¹⁰⁶ Murphy, “What Is a Semiotic Theory of Religion?” 74.

¹⁰⁷ Kaufman, *In Face of Mystery*, 36.

¹⁰⁸ Kaufman, *God—Mystery—Diversity*, 6.

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opt for a different self-understanding. Instead of aspiring to rebuild worldviews from the ground up, theologians might aim rather at making improvisational juxtapositions—between aspects of their tradition and of a contemporary situation—good enough and provocative enough to meet the needs of the present moment. There is an obvious affinity here with Kaufman's notion of theological reconstruction, but the theological task is understood as more tactical and situational, less grandiose and architectonic. The focus is more pointed, and the task might be more manageable.

So much for the possible results of thinking further about a general theory of religion along lines suggested by J. Z. Smith. Earlier, I suggested that a program like Kaufman's could be improved not only by attending to a more adequate theory of religion in general but also by looking more closely at the popular side of religiosity in particular. "Popular religion" is admittedly a contested and problematic category.¹⁰⁹ Despite this, the term effectively captures much of what is neglected in Kaufman's treatment of religion: for example, a focus on short-term problem solving; an interest in supernatural interventions; and the ad hoc, hybridistic use of religious resources.¹¹⁰ Theologians sympathetic to Kaufman's program, but unhappy with the view of religion it incorporates, should pay more attention to this popular dimension of religiosity than does Kaufman. Of course, recent strides have already been made in this direction by theologians of culture like Mary McClintock Fulkerson, Kathryn Tanner, and Sheila Greeve Davaney, and by a host of womanist, *mujerista*, and third-world feminist theologians. Kathryn Tanner, in particular, has been effective in exploring the implications of popular religion for theological methodology. Tanner has made an extensive study of popular religious and social movements. Based on this work, she has suggested that when reconstructing a religious tradition, a theologian may accomplish more by reusing and "recoding" seemingly outmoded parts than by trying (*à la* Kaufman) to make a clean sweep of any and all anachronisms.¹¹¹ A

¹⁰⁹ On debates about what is meant by "popular religion," see Jacques Berlinerblau, "Max Weber's Useful Ambiguities and the Problem of Defining 'Popular Religion,'" *Journal of the American Academy of Religion* 69 (2001): 605–26.

¹¹⁰ On the way that popular religion does incorporate down-to-earth structures based on major life challenges and events, see Damayanthi Niles, "How the Study of Popular Religions Can Help Us in Our Theological Task," *International Review of Mission* 93 (2004): 215.

¹¹¹ Kathryn Tanner, "Social Theory concerning the 'New Social Movements' and the Practice of Feminist Theology," in *Horizons in Feminist Theology: Identity, Tradition, and Norms*, ed. Rebecca S. Chopp and Sheila Greeve Davaney (Minneapolis: Fortress, 1995), chap. 11. On Kaufman's readiness to drop traditional symbols, cf. *In the Beginning . . . Creativity*, 47, 50, 53, 67, 72, 117, 123, 126; "Reading Wittgenstein," 419; *God—Mystery—Diversity*, 22, 23, 64, 112–13, 167; and *In Face of Mystery*, 40, 46, 47, 133, etc.

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constructive theological method informed by an awareness of popular religiosity might follow Tanner's lead on this point. Such a method might also imitate much popular religion by focusing on local interventions—the use of this particular religious resource to address that particular situation—rather than on large-scale system building.

What is the upshot of this exploration? Kaufman's 1972 summons should still resound in the ears of constructive theologians: "Through throwing light on who [she or] he is and on the peculiarities of what [she or] he is doing, the descriptive study of religion should be of importance and aid to the theologian, and this deeper self-knowledge and self-understanding may have profound effects on the way [she or] he does theology as well as on [her or] his theological conclusions."¹¹² In order to heed this call, however, theologians must keep abreast of new theoretical developments, and they must correct for blind spots. I have suggested just two small correctives to Kaufman's program in this article: attending to the work of J. Z. Smith and his conversation partners and taking better note of popular forms of religiosity. Both correctives could point in the direction of a more tactical, ad hoc model for present-day constructive theology than the one Kaufman indicates. While these correctives are small, therefore, they could have important consequences for the way constructive theology is understood and practiced.

¹¹² Kaufman, *God the Problem*, 19.